GOODBYE TIBET, HELLO CHINA

THE DEADLIEST SIN

Jawaharlal Nehru stared angrily out of the car as he made the short drive from Teen Murti, his official residence, to the circular Parliament building in the heart of New Delhi. It was 28 August 1959 and the Indian prime minister was furious at the newspapers for alerting the people of India to the carefully concealed fact that all was not well on the northern border with China. The news report, which blew the lid off the Chinese attack on Indian troops at Longju in NEFA three days earlier, meant that Nehru and his government could no longer conceal the fact that the Panchsheel Treaty signed between India and China in 1954 was dead in the water.

As independent India's first prime minister, Nehru was no stranger to the horrors of war, having presided over the dismemberment of the subcontinent and the subsequent bloodbath that left hundreds of thousands dead. Hardly had the funeral pyres and the graves settled on either side of the newly drawn border than tribal lashkars supported by the Pakistani Army were let loose in Kashmir, leading to more death, rape, and destruction. Even as the country struggled with one domestic crisis after another, the prime minister sought to carve a place for himself on the international stage. He saw himself as the inheritor of Mahatma Gandhi's non-violent legacy and an elder statesman with a global role to play in the postcolonial era. The Ministry of External Affairs, under the stewardship of Nehru himself, was preoccupied with fighting India's Kashmir case at the United Nations while at the same time helping create the platform for Nehru to emerge as the world's leading Afro-Asian leader.

In the early part of 1949, China was not a player as far as India's national security was concerned. The only threat envisaged was from Pakistan, and Nehru airily talked of doing away with an army, claiming that the police was good enough to govern the country and handle external threats. By 1950, the few eyes that were on China knew that Mao Tse-tung